Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**



Jagir Kaur, son Baldev Singh

in the poster are all that she has of the four men. Jagir is standing outside her home in Jeobala village, in the 1.5-acre field that once fed the family. Her younger son Baldev Singh has a protective arm around her shoulders. "We didn't have the resources to even go for the court hearings. But our resolve was strong... emotionally, my mother was my support and I was hers," says Baldev, who himself had been an SPO (special police officer) and was part of controversial cop Ajit Singh Sandhu's team. He had quit just months before his family members disappeared.

> **"We didn't have the resources to even go for the hearings. But our resolve was strong...emotionally, my mother was my support and I was hers"**
>
> **BALDEV SINGH,** who lost his father, brother and two other relatives

Inside the house, there is just one photograph of Piara Singh. Someone took it at a wedding years ago, one guest among many, smiling at the camera. Jagir looks at it often. "My eyesight has weakened," she says. "If he came back today, I don't know whether I would even recognise him."

On July 23, 1992, Piara and the others were picked up by a police party led by DSP Bhupinderjit Singh. They said they were working on a terrorism case and looking for a weapon they believed Piara Singh had knowledge about. "The police said they would question them and bring them back," Jagir Kaur recalls. Baldev was in Kolkata with his elder sister that day. The family went looking, in hospitals, jails and government offices. They begged officials for something, anything. Much later, a distant relative and cop told them that all four had been killed and the bodies thrown in the river Sutlej. Years later, a CBI investigation found evidence backing the family's claims, and convictions followed. But none of it brought closure to the family. ■